Scott Colom Wins Mississippi Senate Seat in Historic First

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Mississippi has a new senator, and his win made history.

Democrat Scott Colom defeated Republican Senator Cindy Hyde-Smith in a close race that took days of ballot counting to settle. Colom, a 43-year-old local **prosecutor**, will become Mississippi's first Black U.S. senator since the years right after the Civil War, a time known as **Reconstruction**. That is a big deal in a state where white **conservatives** have held power for generations. The last time Mississippi voters picked a new Democratic senator was 1947, and the winner then supported **segregation**, the system that kept Black and white people apart by law.

Colom built his campaign around listening. "They actually deserve a senator that will listen to them, that actually cares about what they think, actually cares about what they're going through," he said in the final stretch of the campaign. He also said he could represent all of Mississippi, a state where race has long shaped politics and daily life. He talked about a party that represents rural America, suburban America and urban America, and that delivers for voters instead of offering excuses.

Colom's win adds to a set of **midterm** losses for President Donald Trump's party, which lost races in several states it usually controls. Democratic Senate leader Chuck Schumer celebrated the result online, writing that Colom "ran the campaign of a lifetime and re-imagined what's possible for Democrats in the South." Former President Bill Clinton and former Vice President Kamala Harris campaigned for Colom in the closing weeks. Colom is the son of a man who once worked for President Ronald Reagan as a Republican. When Trump held a **rally** for Hyde-Smith in Corinth, Mississippi, in late October, Colom walked along the line of Trump supporters waiting outside, introduced himself and asked about their concerns. Now he heads to Washington as Mississippi's next senator.

Word Treasure

prosecutor -- A prosecutor is a lawyer who brings cases against people accused of crimes.

Reconstruction -- Reconstruction was the time right after the Civil War when the country rebuilt and set new rules.

segregation -- Segregation was a system of laws that kept Black and white people apart.

conservatives -- Conservatives are people who usually want to keep traditions and change things slowly.

midterm -- A midterm election happens in the middle of a president's term to choose members of Congress and other offices.

rally -- A rally is a big public meeting where supporters gather to cheer for a candidate.

Background you need

The U.S. Senate is one of the two houses of Congress, and each state elects two senators to make laws and vote on big decisions for the whole country.

After the Civil War ended slavery, the years called Reconstruction brought new rules and new rights, but many Southern states then passed laws that kept Black and white people apart.

For generations, white conservatives held most of the power in Mississippi, and race has shaped who wins elections and how people live.

In a midterm election, voters choose members of Congress and other offices in the middle of a president's term, and the results can show how the country feels about the party in power.

Break it down

LEAD: Mississippi has a new senator, and his win made history.

KEY EVENT: Democrat Scott Colom defeated Republican Senator Cindy Hyde-Smith in a close race.

+- WHO: Scott Colom, a 43-year-old local prosecutor, and Senator Cindy Hyde-Smith

+- WHEN: The race took days of ballot counting to settle

+- WHY IT MATTERS: Colom will be Mississippi's first Black U.S. senator since Reconstruction

CONTEXT: The last new Democratic senator was picked in 1947 and supported segregation; white conservatives have held power for generations.

CAMPAIGN: Colom built his campaign around listening and said he could represent all of Mississippi.

REACTION: Democratic Senate leader Chuck Schumer celebrated online, and Clinton and Harris campaigned for Colom.

OUTCOME: Colom heads to Washington as Mississippi's next senator.

Why it matters

A senator helps make the laws for the whole country, so who holds the seat matters to everyone in the state. Colom's win also shows how a state with a long history of racial division can change.

Test what you remember

1. Who did Scott Colom defeat?

(A) Former President Bill Clinton
(B) Republican Senator Cindy Hyde-Smith
(C) Democratic leader Chuck Schumer
(D) President Donald Trump

2. What makes Colom's win historic?

(A) He is the first senator from Corinth
(B) He will be Mississippi's first Black U.S. senator since Reconstruction
(C) He won by the largest margin in history
(D) He is the youngest senator ever

3. When was the last time Mississippi voters picked a new Democratic senator before Colom?

(A) 1968
(B) 1994
(C) 1947
(D) 2008

4. What did Colom build his campaign around?

(A) Building new roads
(B) Listening to voters
(C) Closing schools
(D) Raising taxes

5. Who campaigned for Colom in the closing weeks?

(A) Former President Bill Clinton and former Vice President Kamala Harris
(B) President Ronald Reagan and Senator Cindy Hyde-Smith
(C) His father and his brother
(D) Chuck Schumer and Donald Trump

6. What did Colom do when Trump held a rally for Hyde-Smith in Corinth?

(A) He asked police to close the rally
(B) He walked along the line of Trump supporters, introduced himself and asked about their concerns
(C) He stayed home and watched it on television
(D) He held a rally of his own across town

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: C 4: B 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Scott Colom: Colom said voters deserve a senator who listens and cares, and that he could represent all of Mississippi.

2. Chuck Schumer: The Democratic Senate leader celebrated the result, writing that Colom ran the campaign of a lifetime and re-imagined what is possible for Democrats in the South.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):